



A QUESTION OF TRUST

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Victor Canning

About the Author:

Victor Canning (1911-1986) was a British writer known for adventure, mystery, crime, and suspense stories. His writing often includes clever plots, unexpected twists, and characters who are not exactly what they seem. In **“A Question of Trust”**, he presents a story where a thief who believes he is clever and careful is defeated by someone even smarter than him. The story uses irony to show that crime depends on deception, but criminals themselves can also be deceived.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The danger of trusting appearances and sweet words without proof.
- The irony that a thief himself becomes a victim of another thief.
- Crime, deception, and false respectability in society.
- Overconfidence as a weakness that destroys clever people.

- The difference between being intelligent and being morally right.

Values:

- Honesty and self-control are more valuable than cleverness used for crime.
- Never trust strangers blindly, especially in risky situations.
- Overconfidence can make even a skilled person careless.
- Wrong actions eventually create fear, punishment, and loss of dignity.
- A good life cannot be built through theft, lies, or manipulation.

2. Characters

- **Horace Danby:** A fifty-year-old, unmarried, respectable-looking lock-maker who secretly commits one robbery every year. He is intelligent and skilled, but his greed and overconfidence lead to his downfall.
- **The Young Lady / Real Thief:** A clever woman who pretends to be the owner of the house. She tricks Horace into opening the safe for her and escapes with the jewels, leaving him to be arrested.
- **Sherry:** The small dog in the house. It is friendly and quiet when the young woman commands it, helping her false identity look believable to Horace.
- **The House Owners:** The wealthy owners of the house at Shotover Grange. They are away during the robbery, but their jewels become the target of both thieves.
- **The Police:** They later arrest Horace because his fingerprints are found at the scene, proving that crime leaves evidence behind even when the criminal feels careful.

3. Detailed Summary

“A Question of Trust” is a clever crime story about **Horace Danby**, a respectable-looking lock-maker who secretly lives a dishonest life. He is about fifty years old, unmarried, and successful in his profession. Society sees him as honest and quiet, but once every year he commits a robbery to

buy rare and expensive books.

Horace is not violent, but he is still a criminal. He uses his knowledge of locks and safes to rob rich houses carefully. His love for books becomes an excuse for wrongdoing, showing that education and intelligence are useless if a person lacks honesty and self-control.

For his next robbery, Horace chooses **Shotover Grange**. He studies the house, learns that the owners are away, and plans to steal the jewels kept in the safe. He believes the robbery will be easy because he has prepared well and has done similar crimes before.

Inside the house, Horace begins opening the safe. He is careful but nervous, and his hay fever makes him sneeze because of the flowers in the room. Suddenly, a young woman appears and speaks as if she is the owner of the house. She controls the dog, **Sherry**, confidently, so Horace believes her without proper proof.

The young woman quickly understands that Horace is a thief. Instead of shouting, she traps him with intelligence. She says she will not call the police if he helps her open the safe, claiming that she has forgotten the safe number and urgently needs the jewels for a party. Horace is frightened and accepts her story.

Horace opens the safe without gloves, which becomes his biggest mistake. He leaves his fingerprints behind and gives the jewels to the woman. He thinks he has escaped punishment, but in reality, he has helped another thief commit the robbery.

Later, Horace is arrested because his fingerprints are found on the safe. The truth is revealed: the young woman was not the owner, but a smarter thief who used Horace to steal the jewels. Nobody believes his story because there is no proof of her identity.

The ending is ironic and powerful. Horace, who broke trust through his own crimes, is ruined because he trusted another criminal. The story shows that cleverness without honesty finally collapses, and crime always carries the

risk of fear, humiliation, and punishment.

4. Key Points

- **Horace Danby** looks respectable but secretly commits one robbery every year.
- He steals mainly to buy rare books, but his reason does not justify the crime.
- He plans to rob **Shotover Grange** because the owners are away and jewels are kept in the safe.
- **The young lady** appears and pretends to be the owner of the house.
- Horace believes her and opens the safe without gloves, leaving fingerprints behind.
- The young lady escapes with the jewels, while Horace is arrested and sent to prison.
- The title “**A Question of Trust**” is ironic because a dishonest man is destroyed by trusting another dishonest person.

5. Moral

- Never judge people only by appearance; confidence can hide deception.
- Crime may seem clever, but it finally brings fear, humiliation, and punishment.
- Overconfidence is dangerous because it makes people ignore basic caution.
- A wrong action cannot become right just because the reason sounds harmless.
- Trust must be based on truth and proof, not on fear, panic, or smooth speech.
- Honesty is safer and stronger than cleverness used for dishonest purposes.

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